

Nice to meet you

your shirt is from nineteen seventy-one

i dropped a mitten and you picked it up with the corner
of your shirt, not letting our skin
touch, as though leprosy were alive and well
on your island

i didn't know i'd missed you until yesterday, out there in a cage that
suspends my own
we have needs, sky train rides, chocolate, vitamins,
clean sheets, gentle hands on our body at night
moving

you have had flags rammed into your heart and i stand colonized
by choice
that time someone knifed you in your cave & you killed them, that time i ran
through the park alone at 3am & no one took me down
(the drama of human life always sounds so ludicrous on paper)

your soliloquy is as foreign and familiar as Shakespeare—of Romeo, nephews Brutus and
intercepted mail, fucking and rotten knee-breaking shame

i wanted to bring you my kittens

when arbitrary is your daddy and you want to write a song but
no one noticed your piano fingers in time

you said you know the Chinese mafia, dream of the days when you shovelled
horse manure in spring, want to learn about welding and psychology, once sold crack
from a beautiful wooden box
you said don't ever put the keys in the ignition and get into the car with the doors
unlocked, don't ever

we are not of a different species, but that's how you looked at me when i walked away

For the prisoners of Matsqui, November 2005

Lindsay Anne Lee